Antony and Cleopatra: Key Quotations

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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In the exam, you'll need a secure grasp of the play so that you can draw on significant moments or lines when you write. Being able to recall the text allows you to develop a clear and well-supported interpretation of the play as a whole.

To build a strong response to the theme in the question, you must support your ideas with short quotations or close references to the text. If using short quotations or key words, you must ensure they are directly connected to the point you're making, so that your argument is grounded in the text.

Here, we will analyse key quotes grouped according to the following themes:

- Duty versus desire
- Rome versus Egypt
- Fate and circumstance

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Key quotations are not just for memorising, they are tools to help you prove your ideas in the exam. When revising Antony and Cleopatra, focus on learning short, powerful quotations that link clearly to characters, themes, and key moments in the play.

You should also think about what each quotation shows, not just what it says. A good key quote can reveal a character's motivation, a turning point in the plot, or Shakespeare's message about love, power, or honour. Using a few well-chosen quotations confidently is much more effective than trying to remember lots of long ones.

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Duty versus desire

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> **"... is not more man-like**
> **Than Cleopatra, nor the queen of Ptolemy**
> **More womanly than he;"** — Octavius - Act 1, Scene 4

Meaning and context

- This is delivered by Octavius, reading news of Antony's activities in Egypt:
  - He speaks with a level of disgust about Antony indulging in drinking and partying
- The behaviour is framed as a collapse of classic Roman masculinity, succumbing to the whims of a woman rather than leading as a man:
  - It suggests that women may indulge, but men are serious figures
- Octavius is complaining about Antony's behaviour because he sees the threat of Pompey coming and is angered that his ally is not with him in actions or intent:
  - This feeling is what leads to Octavius not only breaking this alliance, but also his confidence that he can beat him in battle
  - By calling Antony "the abstract of all faults", Caesar presents him as a political liability whose desire has contaminated his sense of discipline and duty

Analysis

- Caesar's use of catalogue and accumulation ("fishes, drinks... wastes / the lamps of night") emphasises how fully Antony has surrendered to pleasure:
  - This is seen as un-Roman, and is basically unacceptable to the men of Rome, whom Antony was once very aligned with
- The contrast between Roman and Egyptian gendered ideals stresses the ideological tension at the heart of the play: Rome values discipline; Egypt represents indulgence:
  - It is very typical of both the time of the play and the time of writing for men to be so bold in their feeling of superiority to women
  - By gendering the behaviour, he is dismissing it as a feminine trait, and saying Antony is no longer a man as he is not disciplined enough to be:
    - Equally, it is both Cleopatra and Egypt's fault, because no man could just choose to be this way, they must be tricked and lost

    - As he tells this to Lepidus, it is meant as a criticism
    - By drifting to this behaviour, he has betrayed Rome and Roman ideals, and is as weak as the indulgent Egyptians:
        - Rome honours duty above all

- This all exposes the theme of Duty versus desire from an external perspective: Antony's private wants are presented as failures of public responsibility, revealing how judgment from Rome shapes the conflict he faces

> **"Let Rome in Tiber melt, and the wide arch**
> **Of the ranged empire fall. Here is my space."** —
> Antony, Act 1, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Antony says this to Cleopatra to show her that he cares more about her than his responsibilities and duty in Rome
- This quote sets up the central conflict of the play:
    - This is the conflict that drives Antony's every action: his duties in Rome versus his desires in Egypt

- The Tiber is a large river that flows through Rome

Analysis

- The imagery of Rome melting into the Tiber dramatises Antony's desire as world-shattering, that he would happily see Rome die for more time with Cleopatra, and shows his priorities from the start of the play:
    - He is already willing to abandon Rome, overwhelmed as he is by desire

- The contrast between imperial grandeur ("ranged empire") and the intimate declaration ("Here is my space") shows the shrinking of Antony's priorities from public to personal:
    - Antony's focus is shifting from public responsibility to private pleasure, proving where his priorities now lie

- The defiant tone positions desire as liberating, even heroic, suggesting that Antony momentarily sees Egypt as a place of self-definition:
    - Antony redefines "nobleness" not as military service, but as their love

- Antony is liberated, relieved of the weight of Rome, which is metaphorically falling off his shoulders as it melts into the Tiber
- However, the extremity of the language hints at instability:
    - The willingness to let Rome "fall" foreshadows the destructive consequences of privileging desire over obligation
    - Completely ignoring responsibility and duty is what leads to Antony's downfall

Help me understand

> **I lose myself.”** — Antony, Act 3, Scene 4

Meaning and context

- Antony says this in discussion with Octavia about his position between Rome and Egypt
- For Antony, his honour is part of his identity, rooted in Roman values:
  - He may act with indulgence in Egypt, but he still feels what he was raised to be
- This is a moment where he is deciding to fight to defend his Roman status:
  - He marries Octavia for the political benefit, and he is torn at that moment, now away from Egypt, about how things are changing for him
- Honour is a core value in Roman society, and Antony expresses the importance of it here:
  - Despite his devotion to and love for Cleopatra, he still recognises that he feels defined by his public honour and the duty he has

Analysis

- The parallel structure of the line reflects Antony’s rigid moral framework:
  - Honour and identity are presented as interchangeable, revealing the intensity of Roman expectations
- The dramatic wording (“I lose myself”) shows how heavy the personal cost feels to him in failing in his duties:
  - He cannot escape the feeling that indulging what he wants is wrong, and that he is less of an honourable man for doing so
  - He does not feel this in Egypt, but back in Rome, the weight of it overwhelms him
- This moment exposes the psychological strain of the play’s central conflict:
  - Antony is torn between two value systems, and honour pulls him back toward Rome even as desire anchors him in Egypt
- The line shows some self-awareness:
  - He understands what he is doing in Egypt, but is choosing to do so all the same
- It also exposes his fragile self-image:
  - He feels he must be dutiful, and is losing respect for himself, and losing the respect of others, in indulging himself in Egypt

> **“O, whither hast thou led me, Egypt?”** — Antony, Act 3, Scene 11

Meaning and context

- He turns on Cleopatra, blaming her for his behaviour:
  - In this moment, Antony is recognising that his actions have consequences, the exact kind of responsibility he has been ignoring
  - “Whither” in this context means “where”, so he is asking where he has been led by his time in Egypt, and suggesting that Egypt and, in turn, Cleopatra, has destroyed his honour

Analysis

- By addressing Egypt as a person, Antony is blaming Cleopatra and her world:
  - This shows him seeing his desire as a force pulling him away from duty
  - He suddenly feels displaced, led astray and changed beyond his control

- In evoking shame, he highlights how internalised Roman expectations of duty are, even though he does not want them and has acted without the weight of them whilst in Egypt:
  - For the first time, he feels the consequences of his time in Egypt, and feels shame and guilt about how he has abandoned his honour and duty

- As he mentions “what I have left behind,” he shows regret for the loss of his reputation:
  - Suddenly, he is judging everything by Roman standards again, reverting to his default in a time of stress and desperation
  - There is a sense of psychological fragmentation, caught between the person he was and the person his desires have made him
  - He feels a loss of self, and the person he knows himself as has been destroyed:
    - This is incredibly unsettling as he cannot see a way to win back that honour that once defined him

Rome versus Egypt

> ”

Meaning and context

- Cleopatra comments this to Charmian as Antony suddenly turns serious when receiving news from Rome
- She is mocking his shift in mood, and the dual personalities he seems to exhibit:
  - This demonstrates that Cleopatra is aware of Antony's shifting moods even when she is not looking directly at him; she knows the "Roman" influence is what pulls him away from her

Analysis

- That anything serious must be a "Roman thought" shows the contrast between Egypt and Rome:
  - In this, we see how Egypt represents emotion and pleasure, while Rome represents rational duty
- In mocking Antony this way, Cleopatra is highlighting his inconsistency and change in behaviour:
  - It shows both of their attitudes to the other's home:
  - Both see Rome as more serious, but to Cleopatra that is a criticism of Rome, whereas Antony's attitude shows he takes Rome more seriously than the fun of Egypt
- For the audience, this shows the weight of expectations to be dutiful:
  - Antony is trained to behave a certain way by Rome, which is unnatural to Egyptians, who have freedom of choice
  - The audience is reminded of the anxiety and strain of living your life in the duty of others
- This may also show that, realistically, Egypt is only a temporary home for Antony:
  - However long he is there, he is still the person that Rome made

> **"Now no more**
> **The juice of Egypt's grape shall moist this lip."** — Cleopatra, Act 5, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Cleopatra says this as she primes herself to die, with Octavius victorious
- Octavius is ready to take Cleopatra to Rome, and parade her as the spoils of his victory:
  - He wants to see her embarrassed, to show the people of Rome that their way is right
- Cleopatra is deeply hurt by Antony's defeat and death, and would rather die with him in honour than be shamed publicly in Rome

indulgence, showing how Egypt and the East are associated with temptation and loss of control:
    - Cleopatra's vow that it will "no more… moist this lip" highlights her desire to see her end, and depart from the glories and indulgence she has enjoyed
    - This shows Cleopatra's awareness of the charmed and fortunate life she has lived:
        - This stands out against the idea she is spoiled and foolish, as here she clearly recognises her luck

- This could also be a sign of her regret that it has ended this way:
    - She knows that there is much sweetness to life to cherish, but which she will no longer enjoy
    - This is not a person sleepwalking to their fate, but choosing it, despite what else could be

- This could simply mean the wine of Egypt, but equally symbolise more:
    - Egypt has been a luxurious land of riches for her, and she is sad to part from it
    - Her deep regret here shows she is sad about her fate, but accepts it

> **"I' th' market place, on a tribunal silvered,**
> **Cleopatra and himself in chairs of gold**
> **Were publicly enthroned. . . ."** — Octavius, Act 3, scene 6

Meaning and context

- This is said by Octavius in discussion with Agrippa and Maecenas
- Octavius is describing Antony's behaviour in Egypt as a betrayal of Roman values
- He recounts a tale of Antony and Cleopatra sitting on public thrones, and Cleopatra dressing as the goddess Isis:
    - Octavius interprets this as Antony embracing Egyptian monarchy and ritual, which he considers treacherous, showing it preference over Roman republicanism

- This report inflames Roman hostility, and Octavius is happy to use it to strengthen his political case against Antony, spreading bad will whenever possible

Analysis

- Octavius' phrase just before this — "Contemning Rome" — directly frames Antony's actions as disrespectful, proving that Egyptian customs are viewed as oppositional to Roman order:
    - By joining Cleopatra when she's dressed as an Egyptian goddess, Octavius sees this as Antony aligning with Egyptian traditions and values over Rome's

links Egypt to divinity and myth, showing how the East embraces ritual and symbolism that Rome distrusts
        - This is pertinent to Shakespeare's audience, who may have mistrusted foreigners and expected Christian values to be spread
- The image of golden chairs and public enthronement shows Egyptian spectacle and ceremonial excess, highlighting Rome's belief that Eastern culture is extravagant and corrupting
- The repeated emphasis on the public eye ("the common showplace") shows the political danger of Antony aligning himself with Egypt, proving the incompatibility between Roman republican identity and Egyptian monarchy:
    - The grandeur is seen as foreign and wrong to Roman identity
- All of this underlines the idea that clashes between Rome and Egypt are not about the two men involved, but a clash of two civilisations:
    - Whilst Egypt is happy to live in its own way and does not care that Rome is different, the expanding and power-hungry Romans are not comfortable with the difference and will not accept it

Fate and circumstance

> **"Swallows have built In Cleopatra's sails their nests.**
> **The augurs**
> **Say they know not, they cannot tell, look grimly**
> **And dare not speak their knowledge."** — Scarus, Act 4 Scene 13

Meaning and context

- Watching as Antony's ships meets Octavius' at sea, Scarus notes that there are swallows' nests in the sails of Cleopatra's ships:
    - This is considered an ominous sign
- The "augurs" cannot determine what it means, but their grim looks and silence on the matter suggest they dare not confirm that this is a bad omen:
    - In ancient Rome, augurs were priests who interpreted the will of the gods by observing signs and omens,

Analysis

- The augurs' fear reveals the severity of the omen, proving that circumstance (not choice) is beginning to dominate the action:
  - It is a sign of just how obsessed with signs and omens the Romans are, that there is a position for a type of priest who interprets signs
  - It is even more surprising that Antony has augurs with him, considering he is away from Rome, marking further their importance
- Their silence suggests that this is a very bad sign, which emphasises just how much they trust in these signs; they are seemingly already accepting defeat
- Whilst Antony gives no suggestion of interest, Scarus is clearly shaken by this sign:
  - Even in the heat of war, it is normal for characters to look to supernatural signs, suggesting this is a normal practice for Romans
  - They appear to believe these signs matter more than strategy
- Sails represent movement, whilst nesting birds suggests obstruction or paralysis:
  - As this is a natural obstruction, it symbolises forces beyond human control working against Antony and Cleopatra

> **"…yet must Antony**
> **No way excuse his foils when we do bear**
> **So great a weight in his lightness."** — Octavius, Act 1, Scene 4

Meaning and context

- Octavius discusses the threat of Pompey in conversation with Lepidus
- Antony is not there at such an important juncture, and Octavius is critical of him for this:
  - They both see Antony's leisurely enjoyment in Egypt as a failure of duty:
    - Both men have stayed true to their Roman ideals, and criticise Antony for not doing so
- Octavius shows his frustration that he and Lepidus must bear his responsibilities themselves:
  - This shows early on that the cracks in their relationship are problematic, even before the issue of Pompey is resolved
  - He wants to ensure that Antony's folly is not forgotten, even after victory against Pompey

Analysis

- Octavius is unhappy with Antony from an early stage of the play, but also smart enough to play the power game with

insulted by Antony, and as allies
    - This could be an early power move, ensuring he has the balance of two against one versus Antony, rather than Lepidus joining Antony
- This also shows how little respect they have for Egypt:
    - They see Egypt and Alexandria as lesser, and as corrupted by indulgence:
        - Antony must be wasting his time in Egypt whilst they live in the "truer" society of Rome

- The line shows another example of how the West sees the East:
    - There is no respect in his tone here, or throughout the speech he delivers to Lepidus

- This foreshadows the true conflict of the play:
    - Whilst we see the triumvirate face and defeat Pompey, Octavius versus Antony is the main story

- This could arguably be seen to also **foreshadow** Lepidus' importance within the group:
    - This is a long speech, directed at Lepidus rather than in conversation, and shows that Octavius sees himself as the main power
    - In this scene, Lepidus is just a figure to reply to the dominant Octavius:
        - In the end, Lepidus is cast aside quickly by Octavius
        - He is so unimportant, his loss of power is not even shown in the play
        - Much like he barely speaks here, his presence, and lack thereof, is hardly acknowledged in the play

> **"It is great**
> **To do that thing that ends all other deeds."** — Cleopatra, Act 5, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Without hope, Cleopatra resigns herself to what she believes is her fate:
    - She concludes she must commit suicide as that is where fate is leading her

- As she believes this her fate, she is taking it with honour:
    - She feels she was destined for this, taking no responsibility for anything that has happened, and resolves to meet it with her head held high

Analysis

- This speech blends her personal despair, the cultural ideals she believes of a monarch and a figure of legend, and the sense that destiny has delivered a final judgement:
    - By seeing it as an inevitable fate, she walks towards it with pride, and without blame

- Equally, her ego demands her to have a death of acclaim, and so painting this as honourable matches this need
- It is possible that Cleopatra is showing she has learned from Antony's Roman honour:
  - The grandeur of the phrasing aligns suicide with Roman honour codes
  - It also reflects Roman heroic values, where a self-inflicted death can be interpreted as honourable resistance to shame or defeat

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